

The Role of Marketing Strategy Localization in the Market Position of Korean Brands in the Iranian Market: A Comparative Case Study of Samsung and LG

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Abstract

International companies operating in foreign markets must balance global brand consistency with adaptation to local market conditions.

Marketing strategy localization is therefore an important consideration in international marketing, particularly when firms operate across markets that differ in consumer preferences, language, culture, institutions, and competitive conditions. This study examines the role of marketing strategy localization in the market position of Korean brands in Iran through a comparative qualitative case study of Samsung and LG. The study employs documentary analysis and comparative case analysis, drawing on academic studies and other relevant secondary sources. The analysis indicates that localization can contribute to the relevance and accessibility of international brands by adapting marketing communication, consumer-facing information, distribution practices, and other market activities to local conditions. Previous empirical research on Samsung in Tehran has identified positive

relationships between several dimensions of localization strategy and brand equity (Babayi & Rahmani, 2015). Other studies concerning Samsung and LG in Iran have highlighted the relevance of perceived quality, brand equity, and distribution (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012; Kafaeipour, 2015). However, localization should not be treated as an independent explanation of market position. Product quality, brand reputation, distribution capabilities, market knowledge, and external market conditions may interact with localization and influence consumer perceptions. The study concludes that effective international marketing requires a balance between global brand consistency and appropriate local adaptation. Localization is therefore better understood as an integrated component of international marketing strategy rather than as a single determinant of market performance.

Keywords: marketing strategy, localization, international marketing, brand equity, Korean brands, Iranian market, Samsung, LG

1. Introduction

International expansion requires companies to operate in markets that may differ substantially from their domestic environments in terms of culture, consumer behavior, language, economic conditions, distribution systems, regulation, and competitive structure. Consequently, international firms must determine which elements of their marketing strategies should remain standardized and which should be adapted to the characteristics of individual markets.

Marketing strategy localization broadly refers to the adaptation of marketing-related activities to the characteristics and requirements of a particular target market. Such adaptation may involve marketing communication, language, product presentation, distribution, customer interaction, pricing practices, partnerships, and other market-facing activities. Localization can allow international companies to make their offerings and communication more relevant to local consumers while maintaining the core identity of the global brand.

The balance between standardization and adaptation has long been discussed in international marketing. Research reviewing the empirical literature indicates that neither standardization nor adaptation can be regarded as universally superior; rather, the appropriate strategic choice depends on the circumstances faced by a firm in a particular foreign market

(Theodosiou & Leonidou, 2003). Similarly, broader global marketing strategy research emphasizes the importance of integrating standardization with other strategic dimensions rather than treating global marketing as a single standardized formula (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). This issue is particularly relevant when international companies operate in markets with distinctive institutional, economic, cultural, and competitive conditions. The effectiveness of adaptation may depend not only on the adaptation itself but also on the firm's broader marketing capabilities and the conditions of the target market.

Korean consumer-electronics companies provide an appropriate context for examining this issue. Samsung and LG have been examined in previous research concerning consumer perceptions, brand equity, localization, and distribution in Iran. For example, Babayi and

Rahmani (2015) examined the relationship between localization strategy and brand equity among Samsung consumers in Tehran and reported positive relationships between several localization dimensions and brand equity.

Research involving both Samsung and LG has also examined the relationship between perceived quality and brand equity among Iranian consumers (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012).

Other research has examined Samsung's distribution strategy in Iran and reported a relationship between distribution strategy and sales promotion (Kafaeipour, 2015).

More recent research has also examined localization in Samsung's Iranian website.

Shokoohifar (2024) found that Samsung's website localization involved a combination of localized elements and global consistency rather than complete cultural adaptation.

Despite this body of research, localization

should not be examined as an isolated explanation of international marketing performance. Product quality, technological innovation, brand image, customer satisfaction, distribution, advertising, and external environmental conditions may also influence the market position of international brands.

Therefore, this study addresses the following main research question:

What role does marketing strategy localization play in the market position of Korean brands in the Iranian market?

The study further examines the following questions:

1. How have Samsung and LG adapted their marketing-related activities to the Iranian market?
2. What forms of localization can be identified in the two cases?

3. How is localization related to brand image and brand equity?
4. What other factors appear to contribute to the market position of Samsung and LG?
5. What external challenges may limit the effectiveness of localization in the Iranian market?

The objective of this study is to examine the role of marketing strategy localization in the market position of Korean brands in Iran through a comparative qualitative case study of Samsung and LG.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

2.1 Market Entry Strategy

Market entry strategy refers to the methods and organizational arrangements through which companies establish and develop activities in foreign markets. These may include exporting, licensing, franchising, partnerships, joint ventures, direct investment, and cooperation with local distributors or other organizations. Market-entry decisions are connected to a company's ability to understand local market conditions, consumer behavior, distribution systems, regulatory environments, and competitive structures. Local partners and distribution networks may provide international companies with access to market knowledge and established commercial relationships. However, market entry and localization should not be considered identical concepts. Market entry describes how a company establishes its

presence in a foreign market, whereas localization concerns the adaptation of activities to characteristics of the target market.

2.2 International Marketing Strategy

International marketing strategy involves the planning and implementation of marketing activities across national markets. These activities include decisions concerning products, pricing, promotion, distribution, communication, and relationships with customers and intermediaries.

A central issue in international marketing is the balance between standardization and adaptation. Standardization can support consistency and operational efficiency, while adaptation can allow companies to respond to differences in consumer preferences, language, culture, economic conditions, and market

structures.

The empirical literature does not support a universal rule that firms should always standardize or always adapt. Instead, the appropriate balance depends on the characteristics of the target market and the circumstances faced by the firm (Theodosiou & Leonidou, 2003). Global marketing strategy can therefore be understood as a broader strategic system incorporating standardization together with other dimensions of international coordination and integration (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002).

2.3 Marketing Localization

Marketing localization refers to adapting marketing activities to the characteristics of a specific target market. It may include language adaptation, communication, product

presentation, customer interaction, distribution practices, pricing considerations, and relationships with local organizations.

Localization is broader than translation alone. A company may translate its website or advertising while maintaining largely standardized marketing practices. Conversely, a company may adapt its distribution, communication, product presentation, customer service, and partnerships while retaining its global brand identity.

Evidence from Samsung's Iranian website illustrates this distinction. Shokoohifar (2024) describes Samsung's approach as involving localized elements while retaining considerable global consistency, rather than representing complete cultural adaptation.

Localization can potentially increase the relevance and accessibility of marketing activities. However, its effectiveness depends on

how successfully adaptation is integrated with broader marketing capabilities and the conditions of the target market.

2.4 Brand Image and Brand Equity

Brand image refers to the perceptions and associations consumers hold about a particular brand. Brand equity represents the value associated with a brand from the consumer's perspective. Keller (1993) conceptualizes customer-based brand equity in terms of the differential effect of brand knowledge on consumer responses to brand marketing, emphasizing brand awareness and brand associations as central components.

Localization may contribute to brand equity when adapted marketing activities improve communication, relevance, and consumer understanding. However, brand equity is not

determined by localization alone.

Babayi and Rahmani (2015) specifically investigated localization strategy and brand equity in the case of Samsung among consumers in Tehran. Their results indicated positive relationships between several localization dimensions—including attribute policy, consumer policy, and application/implementation policy—and brand equity.

Research involving Samsung and LG in Iran has also indicated a relationship between perceived quality and brand equity, suggesting that consumers' evaluations of product quality represent another factor associated with brand value (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012).

2.5 Product Quality and Innovation

Product quality and technological innovation are particularly relevant in consumer electronics and

household appliances. Consumers may evaluate brands according to perceived reliability, performance, technological features, design, and innovation.

Research on Samsung and LG among Iranian consumers has reported a relationship between perceived quality and brand equity (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012).

Therefore, localization should not be considered a substitute for product quality or technological capability. Instead, localization may improve the effectiveness of marketing activities while product quality and innovation contribute to consumer evaluations of products and brands.

2.6 Distribution and Market Accessibility

Distribution represents another important component of international marketing. Even

strong products and brands may face difficulties if consumers cannot access products through reliable channels.

Kafaeipour (2015) examined Samsung's distribution strategy in Iran and reported a relationship between distribution strategy and sales promotion, emphasizing stock management and distribution channels.

This suggests that adaptation can also have an operational dimension. Understanding local distribution structures and managing relationships with intermediaries may help international companies respond more effectively to local market conditions.

2.7 Competitive Positioning

Competitive positioning reflects how a company creates and communicates value relative to competitors. It may be influenced by product

quality, technological innovation, brand reputation, advertising, distribution, customer satisfaction, market knowledge, and adaptation to local conditions.

The theoretical framework of this study therefore treats localization as one component within a broader system of factors influencing international marketing performance. The conceptual relationship can be summarized as follows:

Marketing Strategy Localization → Relevance and Accessibility of Marketing Activities → Consumer Perceptions → Brand Image / Brand Equity → Market Position

However, this relationship is influenced by other factors, including product quality, innovation, advertising, distribution, customer satisfaction, brand reputation, and external market conditions. This framework prevents the study from interpreting localization as a single

independent cause of market performance.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study employs a qualitative comparative case study and documentary analysis approach. Samsung and LG were selected as the two cases because both are Korean consumer-electronics brands with substantial historical relevance to the Iranian market and because academic and documentary material concerning their activities in Iran is available.

The present study does not employ primary surveys, interviews, questionnaires, experiments, or direct observations. Instead, it analyzes

existing documentary evidence, including academic journal articles and previous research studies.

Importantly, some of the secondary studies examined in this paper may themselves have employed primary-data methods such as questionnaires. Such methods belong to those individual source studies and were not conducted as part of the present research. The present study uses their reported findings as secondary documentary evidence.

3.2 Case Selection

Samsung and LG were selected through purposive case selection.

Both companies provide appropriate cases for examining international marketing localization because they have operated in the Iranian consumer-electronics and household-appliance

market and have been examined in previous research concerning consumer perceptions, brand equity, localization, and distribution.

Samsung provides a particularly relevant case because previous research has directly examined the relationship between localization strategy and brand equity among Iranian consumers.

LG provides a complementary case because research involving Samsung and LG has examined perceived quality and brand equity among Iranian consumers.

The comparative design allows similarities and differences between the two cases to be examined while avoiding the assumption that all Korean brands follow identical strategies.

3.3 Data Sources

The documentary material examined in the

study includes peer-reviewed academic journal articles and scholarly research studies concerning Samsung and LG in Iran.

Particular attention was given to sources addressing marketing localization, brand equity, perceived quality, distribution, and website localization.

3.4 Data Analysis

The documentary evidence was analyzed through three stages.

First, evidence concerning Samsung and LG was reviewed separately according to the following analytical categories: market presence and entry, marketing communication, localization, distribution, brand image and brand equity, product quality and innovation, consumer-related factors, and external challenges.

Second, the findings for Samsung and LG were

compared to identify similarities and differences. Third, the comparative findings were interpreted in relation to the theoretical framework concerning standardization, localization, brand equity, quality, distribution, and competitive positioning.

No primary survey, interview, experiment, questionnaire, or direct observation was conducted by the researcher. Because the study relies on secondary documentary evidence rather than primary data, its conclusions should be interpreted as analytical findings from the selected cases rather than statistically generalizable conclusions about all Korean brands or all Iranian consumers.

4. Findings

4.1 Samsung

Samsung represents an important case for examining localization in the Iranian market because previous research has directly investigated its localization strategy and its relationship with brand equity.

Babayi and Rahmani (2015) examined Samsung consumers in Tehran and found positive relationships between several dimensions of localization strategy and brand equity. In particular, attribute policy, consumer policy, and application/implementation policy were reported to have positive relationships with brand equity. These findings suggest that localization may contribute to brand value when marketing activities are adapted to consumer and market characteristics.

Samsung's distribution activities have also been examined in the Iranian context. Kafaeipour

(2015) investigated the company's distribution strategy and reported a relationship between distribution strategy and sales promotion.

Digital communication provides another example of localization. Shokoohifar (2024) examined Samsung's website localization and found that the company's approach combined localized elements with considerable global consistency. The study characterized this approach as closer to globalization or reverse localization than complete culturalization.

This evidence suggests that Samsung's localization should not be understood simply as translating content into Persian. Rather, localization can involve multiple dimensions of the customer experience while preserving elements of the company's global identity.

At the same time, research on Samsung in Iran has identified other factors related to brand equity, including perceived quality and

distribution. Therefore, the available evidence does not support the conclusion that localization alone explains Samsung's market position.

4.2 LG

LG provides a complementary case for comparison.

Research conducted among Iranian consumers has examined LG alongside Samsung and found a relationship between perceived quality and brand equity for both brands (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012).

This finding is important because it demonstrates that consumer evaluation of product quality represents an important factor associated with brand value.

LG's historical position in Iran has also been associated with consumer electronics and

household appliances. However, the available documentary evidence is less directly focused on localization strategy than the Samsung literature. Consequently, claims concerning specific LG localization practices should be interpreted more cautiously unless supported by company documents or additional primary research.

Nevertheless, the comparative evidence suggests that LG, like Samsung, should be examined within a broader framework involving product quality, brand image, innovation, distribution, consumer satisfaction, and adaptation to market conditions.

This distinction is methodologically important: the study does not assume that because Samsung demonstrates a particular localization practice, LG necessarily implemented the same practice to the same degree.

5. Comparative Analysis

5.1 Localization and Market Adaptation

The evidence reviewed in this study suggests that localization can operate at several levels, including language and consumer-facing information, marketing communication, product presentation, distribution, local business relationships, consumer-oriented activities, and digital communication.

Samsung provides particularly clear documentary evidence of this multidimensional approach. Its website localization demonstrates adaptation for Iranian users while retaining elements of global consistency (Shokoohifar,

2024).

The evidence concerning LG is comparatively less detailed, which represents an important limitation of the present study.

5.2 Brand Image and Brand Equity

Both Samsung and LG have been examined in research concerning brand equity and consumer perceptions in Iran.

Amirusefi and Ahrari (2012) found that perceived quality was associated with brand equity for both Samsung and LG among Iranian consumers.

For Samsung specifically, Babayi and Rahmani (2015) found positive relationships between several localization dimensions and brand equity. Together, these findings suggest that localization and product-related perceptions should not be treated as competing

explanations. Instead, they may operate simultaneously. Localization can make marketing activities more relevant and accessible, while perceived quality can strengthen consumers' evaluations of the underlying product and brand.

5.3 Distribution

Distribution represents another area in which local market knowledge can become strategically important.

Kafaeipour (2015) found a relationship between distribution strategy and sales promotion in the case of Samsung in Iran, particularly through attention to stock and distribution channels.

This finding supports the broader argument that international marketing adaptation extends beyond advertising. A company's ability to make products available through appropriate channels

is also part of its interaction with the local market.

5.4 Standardization and Localization

The comparison suggests that the relationship between standardization and localization is better understood as a continuum rather than a binary choice. The broader international marketing literature similarly indicates that the appropriate degree of adaptation depends on the circumstances of the target market rather than following a universal rule (Theodosiou & Leonidou, 2003).

Samsung's website provides an example of this approach: localized elements were present, but the overall strategy retained substantial global consistency (Shokoohifar, 2024).

This supports the argument that international companies may preserve their core brand

identity while selectively adapting specific activities to local market requirements.

5.5 Common Factors Influencing Market Position

Based on the documentary evidence reviewed, several factors appear relevant to the market position of Samsung and LG: perceived product quality, technological innovation, brand image, brand equity, advertising and marketing communication, distribution, consumer understanding, local market knowledge, and appropriate adaptation of marketing activities. The available evidence does not justify ranking these factors according to their relative importance. Instead, they should be viewed as potentially interacting components of international marketing performance.

6. Comparative Table

Table 1

Comparative Overview of Localization-Related Evidence for Samsung and LG

Dimension	Samsung	LG
Localization strategy and brand equity	Direct evidence: Babayi and Rahmani (2015) found positive relationships between attribute policy,	Insufficient direct evidence in the reviewed source base regarding LG-specific localization strategy and its

	consumer policy, and application/ implementation on policy and brand equity among Samsung consumers in Tehran.	relationship with brand equity.
Website/ digital localization	Direct evidence: Shokoohifar (2024) examined Samsung's website localization and found a	Insufficient direct evidence in the reviewed source base.

combination
of localized
elements
with
substantial
global
consistency.

Perceived
quality and
brand equity

Direct
evidence:
Amirusefi
and Ahrari
(2012) found
that
perceived
quality was
associated
with brand
equity
among

Direct
evidence:
Amirusefi
and Ahrari
(2012) found
that
perceived
quality was
associated
with brand
equity
among

	Iranian consumers.	Iranian consumers.
Distribution	Direct evidence: Kafaeipour (2015) found a relationship between distribution strategy and sales promotion for Samsung in Iran.	Insufficient direct evidence in the reviewed source base.
Overall interpretation	Samsung is more directly represented in the	LG is represented primarily through

	reviewed literature concerning localization strategy, website localization, distribution, and brand equity.	comparative research on perceived quality and brand equity. Direct evidence on LG-specific localization practices is limited in the reviewed source base.
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Note. This table summarizes the evidence available in the reviewed source base.

“Insufficient direct evidence” indicates that the reviewed sources did not provide specific information on that dimension for that company. This does not imply that the company did not

engage in such practices.

7. Discussion

The findings support the view that localization can represent an important component of international marketing strategy, but they do not support treating localization as a single or sufficient explanation for the market position of Samsung and LG.

First, localization can increase the relevance and accessibility of marketing activities. Language adaptation, consumer-oriented communication, and localized digital content can reduce communication barriers and make international brands easier for local consumers to understand. The Samsung website study

provides evidence of such adaptation in the Iranian context (Shokoohifar, 2024).

Second, localization may be associated with brand equity. Babayi and Rahmani's (2015) study provides direct empirical evidence from Samsung consumers in Tehran, identifying positive relationships between several localization dimensions and brand equity.

Third, localization interacts with other marketing factors. Research involving Samsung and LG demonstrates the relevance of perceived quality to brand equity among Iranian consumers (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012). Distribution research concerning Samsung also highlights the relevance of channel and stock management (Kafaeipour, 2015).

Fourth, localization should not be interpreted as complete cultural adaptation. International companies may localize specific elements while maintaining a standardized global identity.

Samsung's website provides an example of this balance (Shokoohifar, 2024).

Finally, international marketing performance is shaped by the wider environment in which a company operates. External economic, institutional, supply, and regulatory conditions may influence the effectiveness of company-level marketing strategies. This means that localization should be understood within the broader context of the target market rather than as an isolated managerial action.

Overall, the findings support a balanced standardization-localization perspective.

International companies should preserve the core elements that make their global brands distinctive while adapting market-sensitive activities to local consumer and environmental conditions (Theodosiou & Leonidou, 2003).

8. Managerial Implications

8.1 Conduct Local Market Analysis

Companies should develop a detailed understanding of local consumer expectations, purchasing behavior, communication preferences, cultural characteristics, and competitive conditions before implementing marketing strategies.

8.2 Balance Global Brand Consistency With Local Adaptation

Companies should preserve their core brand identity while selectively adapting communication, product presentation, customer interaction, and other market-sensitive activities.

8.3 Invest in Distribution Capabilities

Reliable distribution is essential for converting brand awareness into market accessibility.

Companies should carefully manage distribution channels, inventory, and relationships with intermediaries.

8.4 Use Local-Language Communication

Providing relevant information in the local language can improve accessibility and consumer understanding. However, translation should be accompanied by appropriate adaptation of communication style and context where necessary.

8.5 Maintain Product Quality and Innovation

Localization should complement rather than replace product quality and innovation. Strong local adaptation is unlikely to compensate for products that fail to meet consumer expectations.

8.6 Monitor External Market Conditions

Companies operating in complex international environments should monitor changes in trade conditions, regulations, supply chains, and consumer purchasing conditions.

8.7 Integrate Localization Into Overall Strategy

Localization should not be treated as an isolated marketing activity. It should be coordinated with product strategy, communication, distribution, customer relationships, and overall brand

management.

9. Conclusion

This study examined the role of marketing strategy localization in the market position of Korean brands in the Iranian market through a comparative qualitative case study of Samsung and LG.

The documentary evidence indicates that localization can contribute to the relevance and accessibility of international marketing activities. In the case of Samsung, previous research has identified positive relationships between several localization dimensions and brand equity among consumers in Tehran (Babayi & Rahmani, 2015). Research on

Samsung's website also demonstrates how localized elements can coexist with a broader global communication strategy (Shokoohifar, 2024).

At the same time, research involving both Samsung and LG indicates that perceived quality is associated with brand equity among Iranian consumers (Amirusefi & Ahrari, 2012). Research on Samsung's distribution strategy further demonstrates the relevance of distribution management to sales promotion (Kafaeipour, 2015).

Therefore, localization should not be considered an independent or sufficient explanation of international brand performance. Rather, it operates alongside product quality, technological innovation, brand image, advertising, distribution, consumer satisfaction, market knowledge, and broader environmental conditions.

The central conclusion is that effective international marketing requires an appropriate balance between global consistency and local adaptation. The international marketing literature does not support a universal preference for either complete standardization or complete adaptation; instead, strategic choices should reflect the circumstances of the target market (Theodosiou & Leonidou, 2003). The comparison of Samsung and LG demonstrates that localization is most appropriately understood as an integrated strategic capability rather than as a single marketing activity. Its effectiveness depends on how well it interacts with broader marketing capabilities and with the conditions of the target market.

10. Limitations and Future Research

This study has several limitations.

First, it relies entirely on secondary documentary evidence and does not include primary interviews, surveys, or direct observations.

Consequently, the study cannot independently measure current consumer attitudes toward Samsung and LG in Iran.

Second, some of the available research concerns historical periods in which the operating conditions of Korean companies in Iran differed from the current market environment.

Third, the available literature is not equally extensive for the two cases. Samsung is more directly represented in research concerning localization, particularly in relation to brand

equity and website localization. Therefore, some conclusions concerning LG are necessarily more cautious.

Fourth, the study focuses on only two Korean brands. The findings should therefore not be generalized automatically to all Korean companies or all international brands operating in Iran.

Fifth, documentary evidence may vary in quality, methodology, and research design. The conclusions of the present study therefore depend partly on the quality and scope of the available secondary sources.

Future research could strengthen the findings by combining documentary analysis with primary qualitative interviews with Iranian consumers, retailers, marketing professionals, and company representatives. Quantitative studies could also examine the relative influence of localization, perceived quality, brand image, customer

satisfaction, and other factors on brand equity and purchase intention.

Future comparative research could further examine other Korean brands, such as Hyundai, Kia, or other consumer-electronics companies, in order to determine whether the patterns identified in the Samsung and LG cases extend to other Korean brands.

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